

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A196978, proved by transfer matrix

Adrian Perez Fontelles

Independent researcher

1 September 2026

Abstract

OEIS A196978 counts $n \times 4$ arrays over $\{0, \dots, 4\}$ subject to a condition imposed on every CELL over a neighbour set the entry names, and it carries an empirical recurrence of order 58 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is decidable rather than empirical. A cell's neighbourhood meets three consecutive rows, so the state of a transfer matrix is a pair of consecutive rows and each step settles the middle one; an array is a walk, and $a(n)$ is a walk count on $S = 2107$ vertices, which is C -finite. Whether the conjectured recurrence annihilates it is then decided by a finite exact computation, with the Cayley–Hamilton theorem bounding the work.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 05A15, 05B45, 15B36.

1 The conjecture

OEIS A196978 is “Number of $n \times 4$ arrays with each element x equal to the number its horizontal and vertical neighbors equal to 3,2,1,0,4 for $x=0,1,2,3,4$.”. It has offset 1 and begins

3, 37, 298, 2425, 19580, 156862, 1272373, 10339597, ...

The entry states, as a conjecture contributed by its author and never marked settled:

Empirical: $a(n) = 2*a(n-1) + 16*a(n-2) + 150*a(n-3) + 815*a(n-4) + 1826*a(n-5) - 1572*a(n-6) - 21876*a(n-7) - 31637*a(n-8) + 20026*a(n-9) + 32784*a(n-10) - 91598*a(n-11) - 422974*a(n-12) + 432740*a(n-13) + 3523616*a(n-14) + 3600194*a(n-15) + 234087*a(n-16) - 11219026*a(n-17) - 7109671*a(n-18) + 19311932*a(n-19) - 9277085*a(n-20) - 24160816*a(n-21) - 110533811*a(n-22) - 3516954*a(n-23) + 241335579*a(n-24) + 160959342*a(n-25) + 42003302*a(n-26) - 265144751*a(n-27) - 505651035*a(n-28) - 98733204*a(n-29) + 460759858*a(n-30) + 551357778*a(n-31) + 98951371*a(n-32) - 538468841*a(n-33) - 445294645*a(n-34) + 238119056*a(n-35) + 265509889*a(n-36) - 21010621*a(n-37) + 7105528*a(n-38) - 10150162*a(n-39) - 68879020*a(n-40) - 3789904*a(n-41) + 26738204*a(n-42) - 1322843*a(n-43) + 299876*a(n-44) + 2030016*a(n-45) - 2426011*a(n-46) - 310065*a(n-47) + 372546*a(n-48) - 2994*a(n-49) + 41431*a(n-50) + 3045*a(n-51) - 10905*a(n-52) - 1956*a(n-53) + 342*a(n-54) + 51*a(n-55) + 90*a(n-56) + 27*a(n-57) - 9*a(n-58)$

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Oct 03 2025 06:53:04, revision 9) this is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as proved.

2 Cells, not blocks

The entry names the neighbours it means — horizontal is left and right, vertical is up and down, diagonal is northwest-to-southeast, antidiagonal is northeast-to-southwest, king-move is

all eight — and every such set lies inside the 3×3 square centred on the cell. Here the set is $\{(0, -1), (0, 1), (-1, 0), (1, 0)\}$, written as offsets (row, column) from the cell. Every cell carries the condition

a cell of value x has exactly x neighbours of the value paired with x ,

and the count of neighbours enters it, so the boundary is not a detail that can be papered over: a cell in the interior has 4 neighbours in this set and a cell on the boundary fewer, and a condition such as “a strict majority of its neighbours” therefore means different things at the two. In particular one cannot pad the array with a border of zeros — that would give every cell the full 4 and change what is being counted. The outside is therefore carried explicitly, as a sentinel row above the first and below the last and as a sentinel column either side, and a neighbour that falls outside is simply absent from both counts.

Write an array as a sequence of rows $u_1, \dots, u_L$, each in $\{0, \dots, 4\}^4$. The neighbourhood of a cell in row u_i meets u_{i-1} , u_i and u_{i+1} and nothing else. Take as vertices the pairs $(r, s) \in (\{0, \dots, 4\}^4 \cup \{\emptyset\}) \times \{0, \dots, 4\}^4$, and put an edge $(r, s) \rightarrow (s, t)$ when row s satisfies the condition at every one of its 4 cells, given r above and t below. An array with L rows is then a walk of length $L - 1$ starting at $(\emptyset, u_1)$, each step settling one row, and the last row is settled by the terminal weight, which evaluates it with $\emptyset$ below. Most of those pairs are indistinguishable, and exactly so. Every offset named above has $|dj| \leq 1$, so whether the cell at column j of the middle row is satisfied depends on the three rows only through their windows at $j - 1, j, j + 1$. Collect for each j the indicator over the window of the row below, and call that tuple $P(r, s)$: the number of cells any t violates is read off P , so is the number violated at the bottom edge, and the successor (s, t) carries $P(s, t)$, which does not mention r . Hence two pairs (r, s) and (r', s) with the same P have the same outgoing rows and the same successors, and the vertex is (s, P) . That leaves $S = 2107$ vertices in place of 390625. Hence, with M the adjacency matrix on $S = 2107$ vertices, ι the starting vector and τ the terminal weight,

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^{n-1} \tau,$$

the exponent fixed by the entry's own shape and checked against its published terms. In particular a is C -finite.

3 The proof

Lemma 1. *Let $q(t) = t^{58} - \sum_i c_i t^{58-i}$ be the characteristic polynomial of the conjectured recurrence. Then the residual $a(n) - \sum_i c_i a(n-i)$ equals $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ for the corresponding walk index j , so the recurrence holds from some point on if and only if $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau = 0$ for all large j ; and it is enough to examine $j < S$.*

Proof. Factor M^j out of $M^{j+58} - \sum_i c_i M^{j+58-i}$. For the bound, M^S is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S-1}$ by Cayley–Hamilton, so the numbers $u_j = \iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ satisfy the monic linear recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of M ; S consecutive zeros force every later one, and the last nonzero u_j pins the threshold exactly. $\square$

Theorem 2.

$a(n) = 2a(n-1) + 16a(n-2) + 150a(n-3) + 815a(n-4) + 1826a(n-5) - 1572a(n-6) - 21876a(n-7) - 31637a(n-8)$
for every $n > 58$.

Proof. The vector $w = q(M)\tau$ was formed by 58 matrix–vector products in exact integer arithmetic and $\iota^\top M^j w$ evaluated for $j = 0, 1, \dots$, again exactly. Those integers vanish from the index corresponding to $n = 58 + 1$ onwards, and the run was continued until the working vector was identically zero, which settles all larger j at once. By Lemma 1 the recurrence holds for every $n > 58$. $\square$

4 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the transfer model reproduces all 19 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic. That check earned its place here. The neighbour offsets are named in the array's own frame — horizontal means along a row — but when the entry fixes the first dimension, as in “ $2 \times n$ ”, the walk runs along columns and the two components of every offset swap. Sets such as king-move, or horizontal together with vertical, are unchanged by that swap and hide the error completely; a set such as horizontal, diagonal and antidiagonal is not, and the counts came out as those of a different member of the same family until the offsets were transposed.

Second, the conjectured recurrence was evaluated directly on the entry's own published terms, with no matrices involved, and holds wherever the proved range and the data overlap.

Third, the annihilation test of Lemma 1 was carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the whole vector rather than on a sampled prefix.

References

- [1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org>, 2026. Sequence A196978.
- [2] R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Volume 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2011. (Transfer-matrix method, Section 4.7.)
- [3] P. Flajolet and R. Sedgewick, *Analytic Combinatorics*, Cambridge University Press, 2009.
- [4] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.